

THE MOTOWN UNIVERSE

Executive Development Memo #001 — Launch Year & Franchise Name
An alternate-reality “what if” • Fidelity Rating: 100% • Nerf Tolerance: 0%

1. The Decision

FRANCHISE: The Motown Universe (TMU) (internal name, see Memo #007)

FIRST FILM RELEASE YEAR: 2009

**Announced Mon. Jan 12, 2009 • Premiere Tue. Apr 14, 2009 (Fox Theatre, Detroit) • Wide
release Fri. May 1, 2009 (updated in Memo #009)**

2. Why 2009 Is the Perfect Year

- **The Golden Anniversary.** Berry Gordy founded Tamla Records on **January 12, 1959** with an **\$800 loan** from his family's savings fund. January 12, 2009 is the 50th anniversary to the day — the announcement date writes its own press release.
- **The blueprint is fresh.** *Iron Man* (May 2, 2008) proved the shared-universe model. Launching one year later lets TMU follow the playbook while it is new, and taking the first-Friday-in-May slot mirrors Marvel's own launch window.
- **Audiences want music biopics.** *Ray* (2004) and *Walk the Line* (2005) were critical and commercial hits. *Dreamgirls* (2006) fictionalized a Supremes-style story. TMU answers that with the **real names, real songs and real chart history**.
- **Detroit's comeback story.** In 2009 GM and Chrysler went through bankruptcy. Gordy took the assembly-line idea from his time at the Lincoln-Mercury plant and used it to build a hit factory. A movie about Detroit building something world-class out of nothing lands hardest that year.
- **The legends can advise us.** In 2009 Berry Gordy, Smokey Robinson, Stevie Wonder, Diana Ross, Mary Wilson, Martha Reeves and Holland–Dozier–Holland were all alive to consult. We never get a better chance to check the facts with the people who were there.

Sensitivity note

Michael Jackson died on June 25, 2009, during our first year. Whenever the Jackson 5 story is developed, it gets full-strength, respectful treatment. It is never rushed out to cash in.

3. Why “The Motown Universe” Is the Perfect Name

Candidate	Verdict
The Motown Universe (TMU)	SELECTED. Leads with the brand. Its acronym, TMU, is ours alone. It matches the project name we already use.
Motown Cinematic Universe	Rejected. The “MCU” acronym belongs to Marvel. We'd be a copy on day one.
Hitsville Cinematic Universe	Rejected. It names only the studio building, not the whole Motown story.
The Sound of Young America Universe	Too long as a name. Kept as the official tagline , since it was Motown's real slogan.

Internal lockup (CONFIDENTIAL, see Memo #007): *THE MOTOWN UNIVERSE — The Sound of Young America*. It is not used publicly until the reveal. Studio-logo idea for Motown Productions: the Hitsville U.S.A. house at **2648 West Grand Boulevard**, Detroit, lighting up as a Funk Brothers groove plays.

4. Studio Mandates (Non-Negotiable)

The Fidelity Mandate

- The “source material” is the **master recordings, Billboard chart history, and first-hand memoirs**: Gordy's *To Be Loved* (1994), Smokey's *Smokey: Inside My Life* (1989), Mary Wilson's *Dreamgirl: My Life as a Supreme* (1986), Martha Reeves' *Dancing in the Street* (1994), and Allan Slutsky's *Standing in the Shadows of Motown* (1989).
- Names, dates, chart positions and songwriting credits must match the record. We do not invent composite characters to stand in for real people.
- Gordy is shown whole: a genius and a hard-driving boss. That includes the Friday Quality Control meetings, the move to LA in 1972, and the \$61M sale to MCA/Boston Ventures in 1988.

The No-Nerf Mandate

- **Nobody gets nerfed.** Every artist appears at their full documented level of talent and achievement. Examples: the Supremes' 12 Hot 100 #1s, Stevie playing many instruments, Marvin Gaye's three-octave-plus range, and Smokey as a poet-level lyricist.
- The **Funk Brothers** get full on-screen credit and real story arcs, especially James Jamerson (bass) and Benny Benjamin (drums). They are not background extras.
- **Holland–Dozier–Holland**, Norman Whitfield, Mickey Stevenson and the whole writing and production staff get the same treatment as the stars.
- Every performance uses the original masters or a live vocal that matches the record. Weak lip-syncs are not allowed.

*TMU is a fan-made alternate-reality concept. It has no connection to Motown Records,
Universal Music Group or Marvel Studios.*